This chapter therefore looks to lawmaking by parliament, and the dual capacity of law to both manage and engender conflict. There has been broad recognition that the Union Parliament, a new body in the legal landscape of Myanmar, has found its voice and begun to assert its power in the past few years (ICG 2013; Kean 2014). In fact, we could go as far as to say that parliament has been the most aggressive institution in the period from 2011–2015, resisting any perceived or real attempts by the president or the courts to limit its power. Scholarship has drawn attention to the personalities and political parties in the Union Parliament, particularly the military representatives (Egreteau 2015a, 2015b; Kean 2013; Republic of the Union of Myanmar 2013). There has also been a focus on the process of lawmaking in parliament, that is, the increase in lawmaking activities, the vigour of debate, and attention to the role of members of parliament in the legislative process, including which members or political parties proposed, supported, or rejected which bills (ICG 2013; see also Chit Win, this volume). This has highlighted the way military officers have not always voted in line with the majority Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP), nor in a uniform bloc. However, there has been less focus on the substance and form of laws passed by parliament in light of past lawmaking practices, nor acknowledgement of the role of parliament in relation to conflict.

In 2010, its final year in power, the military junta known as the State Peace and Development Council passed a range of legislative reforms in preparation for the new political regime. Since 2011, there has been an increase in legislative reform in areas as diverse as foreign investment; farmland; labour rights; media reforms; civil society organizations, and the Central Bank. The first new Union Parliament sat in fourteen sessions from 2011 to 2015 and debated a wide range of policy reforms. Law reform that in many other countries would have taken years has seemingly appeared overnight. Yet many of these reforms are not necessarily new, and follow a pattern set by the previous military government, which did undertake legislative reform after 1988 and the democracy uprising. In fact, the military regime was meticulous in recording and publishing its legislative activities. Since 1988, all legislation in Myanmar has been published in annual edited volumes, in both English and Burmese (see Union of Myanmar 1999–2013).[1] All laws are published in the government-run Government Gazette as well as in some local newspapers, and more recently online on various government websites. There is, therefore, greater